

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

## ALT this month:

We speak to the CEO of Audible, chart out the home planets of popular aliens from sci-fi shows, explore the evolution of fake news and there's always our lifestyle section, DGT.



## Letterlocking to protect messages

Before cryptography and even envelopes, people used to use a technique known as letterlocking to protect messages from being intercepted. There are hundreds of types of these locks, from simple wedges to booby traps that look like other letterlocks. These techniques were used by the royalty and spymasters, at a time when letters served as their own envelopes.

<https://dgit.in/letterlocks>

## WHAT'S NEW

# The Dead Celebrity Hologram Industry

**A**my Winehouse is slated to go on tour eight years after her death in 2011, using a controversial new technology that allows holograms of celebrities to be cast on stage. There are two sides of the issue, fans who do not want the images and personas of the dead celebrities to be commercially exploited, and other fans who see no problem with such holograms used to fund charities. It is also an opportunity for newer fans, who have never seen the artist on stage, perform live. The actual technology of projecting people on stage is very old, and the first form of it was invented way back in 1862. Since then, it has been used in stage shows and amusement parks, in more



or less the same form. The technologies being used now include motion capture, 3D modelling and face tracking for more accurate

representations, of higher fidelity. After all this is the question of what happens when holograms become normal. It is quite possible that once the novelty factor ceases to exist, then the now popular dead celebrity hologram industry could soon be adversely affected.

<https://dgit.in/dedgram>

## The paperclip maximiser

**I**n 2003 Nick Bostrom, a Swedish philosopher outlined a thought experiment known as the "paperclip maximiser". The idea was to show how a relatively harmless task given to an artificial intelligence can result in an existential crisis for mankind. The AI is given one simple task, make as many paperclips as possible. Now the AI starts building paperclip manufacturing facilities and producing paperclips. It then



notices that humans may turn it off once they have enough paperclips, and additionally, human beings have plenty of atoms that can be made into paperclips. So, the AI goes

rogue and destroys humans and converts them to paperclips. Then, the AI converts the Earth into paperclips, and starts expanding into space. Eventually, the universe would be full of paperclips. The underlying idea is to demonstrate the need for incorporating human ethics into artificial intelligences, so that such scenarios of AI going rogue does not happen.

<https://dgit.in/pcmmax>



## The collapse of the tech mythology

Silicon Valley and the tech companies that it spawned have long been celebrated in the United States. Now, many of these companies are facing a backlash and there are serious questions being asked about the methodologies that these companies make use of in their operations.

<https://dgit.in/techlapse>



## You are Jeff Bezos

This is an interactive piece of fiction, where you wake up in the morning as Jeff Bezos, and you continue to earn money at the rate that Bezos does. Your challenge is to spend all of the money as quickly as possible. The exercise puts into perspective the kinds of problems you can solve with all that money.

<https://dgit.in/bezosim>



## What if the placebo effect is not a trick?

"Fake Medicine" use the placebo effect to make the patients feel like useless pills, for example, capsules of sugar are actually healing them in some way. New research into the placebo effect casts light on how the body heals itself and more.

<https://dgit.in/placeboreal>